ended; the decree was dated March 11, 1152.

Eleanor, now aged twenty-eight, left her two girls in the care of their father and went at once to the French town of Poitiers. There, she was joined by young Henry; and on May 18, only two months after her marriage to the king ended, Eleanor and Henry were married.

More than one contemporary chronicler chalked the sudden marriage up to infatuation. Henry and Eleanor had met earlier in the year, when Geoffrey and his son visited the French court to pay their respects to the king; Henry's mother Matilda was ten years older than his father Geoffrey—still only thirty-nine at the time of his death—so the age difference seemed perfectly normal to the young count. And since the marriage would eventually yield eight children in fourteen years (as opposed to the two Eleanor had produced in her fifteen years with Louis), sex was obviously part of the equation. But by marriage, Henry gained the vast rich territory of Aquitaine to add to his already extensive lands, and Eleanor gained the protection of the most powerful nobleman in Western Francia.

And the wedding also weakened Louis, who lost half of his domain to his rival.

Louis, motivated by equal parts fury and prudence ("He was greatly incensed against Duke Henry," remarks Roger of Wendover, undoubtedly understating Louis's emotions), mounted an immediate war against the newlywed Count of Anjou. But Henry was no longer the unprepared fourteen-year-old of 1147. His men drove off Louis's attacks, and Henry's return forays into royal land forced Louis to suggest a truce: he would recognize Henry's claim to Aquitaine, as long as Henry would swear an oath of loyal submission to the French throne.[4]

Henry agreed. His power in Western Francia was secure—his lands were more than seven times larger than Louis's royal estates—and he had his eyes on England. His mother Matilda, worn out by a decade of struggle, had retreated back to Normandy; he intended to pick up the fight.

In January of 1153, Henry once again landed on English shores, this time at the head of three thousand men. Almost at once, he took the castle of Malmesbury away from Stephen's forces, and used it as a base to campaign forward across the countryside. By the first week of August, Henry's troops had reached the Thames.[5]

Just days later, Stephen's son and heir Eustace died of a sudden onset of seizures, and Stephen lost the heart to continue with the fight. He proposed a truce. He would continue to rule as king of England until his death; Henry would swear loyalty to Stephen as his lord. In exchange, Henry would become heir to the crown after Stephen's death.